Already, by February 1948, many of the Palestinian élite, such as landowners and business people, had left Palestine. This contributed to feelings of insecurity among the Arab masses, especially in the villages, and encouraged others to leave. Then, in April 1948, Jewish forces began the forcible expulsion of Arabs from villages inside what was to become the Jewish state. Nearly all of the villages along the coast from Tel Aviv to Haifa (see the map on page 20) were cleared of their Arab populations. Armed Jewish forces surrounded each village on three sides, forcing the villagers to flee through the fourth side. If the people refused to leave, they were often forced on to lorries and driven away to Transjordan. Similarly, Jewish forces took over mixed Arab–Jewish towns like Jaffa and Haifa. In Haifa, where explosions were set off by Jewish forces in Arab areas of the city, nearly all of the Arab population of 100,000 fled.

The battle for Jerusalem

There was a particularly bitter struggle to control the roads leading to Jerusalem and massacres of civilians were carried out by both sides. Some of the massacres by Jewish forces were in retaliation for Palestinian attacks on Jewish settlements or on convoys trying to supply the Jewish population of Jerusalem. However, the targets for Jewish attacks were not random: they were carefully chosen. They were intended to rid the future Jewish state of as many Arabs as possible. In the weeks before the British withdrawal from Palestine, some of the bloodiest fighting took place in and around Jerusalem. In one well-known incident, in April 1948, Irgun fighters, led by Menachem Begin, attacked the village of Deir Yassin (which was inside what was to be Arab territory under the UN plan) and killed the inhabitants. They said they believed it was an Arab headquarters. The effects of incidents like this were dramatic. As Begin himself wrote later:

> The Arabs began to flee in terror even before they clashed with Jewish forces. … Arab propaganda spread a legend of terror amongst Arabs and Arab troops, who were seized with panic at the mention of Irgun soldiers. The legend was worth half a dozen battalions to the forces of Israel.

By 14 May 1948, when the British finally withdrew from Palestine, over 300,000 Arabs had left what was to become the new Jewish state. This was a victory for the Jews but a disaster for the Arabs.

Key date

British withdrawal from Palestine: 14 May 1948